The Family Phone Agreement

The first phone is a big moment.
Let's do it well.



Not a list of rules handed down. A deal your family writes together, signs together, and grows together as trust grows.

The conversation **The agreement** **The pathway**

FIVE MINUTES BEFORE THE BIG MOMENT

Why a ceremony beats a lecture

The night your child gets their first phone, they will remember how it felt. Make it feel like joining something, not signing surrender papers. So you sit at the table, you talk it through, and you both put your names on a deal you built together. A lecture is over in a minute. A deal you both signed is still on the fridge next term.

THEIR PEN, NOT YOURS

The child writes their own promises in their own handwriting. A rule done to a child gets tested. A promise written by a child gets defended, by them, because it is theirs. Your job is to ask good questions and hold the pen for your half only.

THE DEAL GROWS

This is not a fixed fence. It is a pathway. Every school term you review the deal together, and where trust has grown, the deal loosens. Your child can see the next step on page six, which means they are working towards something, not pushing against you.

THE GOLDEN RULE

This agreement binds both sides. You sign promises too: to knock before you look, to change the deal together rather than by ambush, to answer any question without anger. A deal that only binds the child is not a deal. It is a trap with a signature line, and children can smell the difference instantly.

HOW TO RUN THE EVENING

1. Talk through page three together before the phone comes out of the box. Questions first, phone second.
2. Fill in the agreement side by side. They write their promises, you read yours out loud.
3. Sign, date, and mark the first review date on the calendar there and then.
4. Hand over the phone. Take a photo of the signed page. That photo is the family's receipt.

Print the whole pack on A4. The agreement spread looks its best on slightly heavier paper, and it belongs on the fridge or the pinboard, not in a drawer.

BEFORE THE PHONE · TALK FIRST, SIGN SECOND

Five questions to talk through together

There are no wrong answers here. Jot down what you both said, because what you decide tonight becomes the agreement on the next page.

Q1 What is this phone actually for?

Calling home? Music? Messaging friends? Name the top three jobs it does.

Q2 Who pays for what?

The phone, the monthly plan, a cracked screen, extras inside apps. Decide now, laugh about it now, not mid argument later.

Q3 What happens at bedtime?

Where does the phone sleep, and when does it go there? Hint: phones sleep better outside bedrooms, and so do their owners.

Q4 What would you do if a stranger messaged you?

Let your child answer first. Then build the plan together. Page seven turns this one into three steps worth keeping.

Q5 What happens when we get it wrong?

Not if. When. Everyone in this family will fumble this at some point, parents included. Decide how we put it right and move on.

DiGi's tip for parents: for every question, say what YOU find hard about your own phone. Honesty going one way is an interview. Honesty going both ways is a family.

My promises

Written in my own words, in my own handwriting, because this deal is mine too.

1 **Where my phone sleeps at night:**

2 **On school nights, my screens go down at:**

3 **Before I download a new app, I will:**

4 **If something on my phone feels wrong, I will tell:**

5 **At mealtimes, our phones live:**

Write what you really mean, not what sounds good. A promise you chose is a promise you can keep. Your parents sign their half on the next page.

OUR FAMILY PHONE AGREEMENT · PART TWO

Our promises to you

This deal binds both sides. Here is our half, read out loud before we sign.

- **We will knock before we look.** Your phone is part of your world, and we treat it with the same respect as your bedroom door.
- **We change this deal together, never by ambush.** No rule appears out of nowhere. If something needs to change, we sit at this table again.
- **We will answer any question without anger.** Whatever you find, whatever you are asked, whatever you saw. Bring it to us and we will stay calm.
- **We remember we are learning too.** Nobody handed us a manual for this either. When we get it wrong, we will say so.

SIGNED BY ME	SIGNED BY US	DATE
_____	_____	_____
NAME AND SIGNATURE	PARENT NAME AND SIGNATURE	THE BIG DAY

We review this deal every school term, and where trust has grown, the deal grows with it.

REVIEW ONE	REVIEW TWO	REVIEW THREE
_____	_____	_____

The _____ family · one deal, both sides

THE PATHWAY · HOW THE DEAL GROWS

Trust levels

The deal is not a wall, it is a path. Every term review, look at each row together and ask one question: has this been going well? If yes, step right. That is the whole system. Freedom is earned by showing you can carry it, and it is visible, so nobody has to nag and nobody has to guess.

	1 · Getting started	2 · Growing trust	3 · Earned freedom
Bedtime	Phone charges in the kitchen every night, handed over at the agreed time without being asked.	Phone stays out later on weekend nights. School nights stay the same, because sleep is not negotiable yet.	You set your own switch off time and the phone still makes it to the kitchen. We just spot check the deal at reviews.
New apps	Every new app is a conversation first. We look at it together before it goes on the phone.	You download first, then show us within a day. We trust your judgement and we stay curious, not suspicious.	Your choices, your call. We only ask that anything involving strangers or spending still gets a mention at dinner.
Out and about	Phone comes along for calls and messages home. A quick message when plans change.	You manage your own messages home. We agree the pattern once and stop reminding you.	You run your own comings and goings. We know you will tell us what we need to know, because you always have.

THE TERM REVIEW IN THREE QUESTIONS

1. What went well this term? · 2. What felt too tight, or too loose? · 3. Which rows step right, and which stay put?

Ten minutes, biscuits on the table, child answers first. Then write the new levels below and date the next review on page five.

WHERE WE START

We are starting at level _____ for bedtime, level _____ for apps, and level _____ for out and about.

Rows can sit at different levels. Most families start everything at level one and that is a fine place to start.

A STEP BACK IS NOT A FALL

If a level stops going well, step left for a while and try again next review. No drama, no shame. That is the deal working, not the deal failing.

FOR YOU · KEEP THIS ONE FOREVER

When something feels wrong

One day your phone will show you something that makes your tummy drop. A weird message, a mean group chat, a picture you did not ask for. It happens to everyone. You do not need to fix it. You just need these three steps.

1

Stop

Put the phone down. Do not reply, do not argue, do not click. Nothing needs answering right now.

2

Keep it

Screenshot it if you can. Forward it to nobody, not even a friend. Do not delete it. It is proof, not your fault.

3

Tell your adult

Today, not someday. Say "something on my phone felt wrong" and hand it over. They signed a promise to stay calm.

You will never be in trouble for telling.

Not even if you clicked something. Not even if you broke a rule first. Telling is always the winning move in this family.

PARENTS · RUN THE DRILL ONCE

The night you sign, practise it at the table. Ask "so a stranger messages you tomorrow, what happens?" and let your child walk the three steps out loud. Practised when nothing is wrong, the steps are already familiar if a real day ever comes.

CUT OUT · ONE FOR YOUR POCKET, ONE FOR YOUR SCHOOL BAG

☆ **When something feels wrong**

1. Stop. No replies, no clicks.
2. Keep it. Screenshot, forward nothing, delete nothing.
3. Tell your adult today.

YOU ARE NEVER IN TROUBLE FOR TELLING

☆ **When something feels wrong**

1. Stop. No replies, no clicks.
2. Keep it. Screenshot, forward nothing, delete nothing.
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YOU ARE NEVER IN TROUBLE FOR TELLING

THE GUIDED CHILDHOOD PASSPORT

Your Passport stickers

The Family Phone Agreement belongs on the Bloop page (ages 8 to 10) or the Orbit page (ages 11 to 12), under the talk, in the Guided Childhood Passport. When your family has used the agreement, tick it in the Go further strip on that page, then cut out the sticker and stick it on. The big one fits the stage page and the small one fits the fold out passport.



PRINT THIS PAGE ON STICKER PAPER, OR ON PLAIN PAPER WITH A GLUE STICK

No Passport yet? Look for the Guided Childhood Passport in the same Etsy shop: five stage pages for ages 4 to 16, each one stamped when the talk, the doing and the check are done.



A FREE GIFT FOR YOUR FAMILY

As a thank you, the full Guided Childhood Starter Pack is yours free: the star chart, the jobs that earn the stars, and a whole booklet of things to do away from a screen. Pop your email in at the address below and it is yours.

guidedchildhood.com/etsy-bonus

Made by Justin at Guided Childhood, a dad who got tired of the screen time fight. If this agreement helped your family talk it through, a kind review on Etsy helps another family find it before their big day.